proposal to the president suggesting the speedy invasion of the island. It was after 10:00 a.m. that LeMay told the gathering: “We should write a simple paper, taking the latest intelligence into account, and again recommending the execution of a full-scale OPLAN 312 followed by OPLAN 316.”

The first of these, codenamed “OPLAN 312–62,” envisioned an air strike on the island targeting first missile, aircraft, and antiaircraft installations, then transportation and communication networks, and finally troop concentrations. Fifty-two aircraft would begin the operation, their number to be increased after the first six hours to 384, and after twelve hours to 470. OPLAN 316–61 envisioned the invasion of the island with two airborne divisions and one infantry division, joined by a Marine division and a brigade, accompanied by an armored combat command. The amphibious assault was planned to take place three days after the receipt of the order by the troops, and the airborne assault five days after that.[2]

When Robert McNamara joined the meeting around 1:30 p.m., soon after President Kennedy adjourned the morning meeting of the ExCom, the paper was ready and presented to him by the chiefs. It proposed the “early and timely execution” of OPLAN 312. McNamara asked what that actually meant, and LeMay answered: “Attacking Sunday or Monday.” That meant the next day or the day after—October 28 or 29. McNamara was in favor of the strike but needed more time, as he had to wait until the issue of American missiles in Turkey was resolved. General Maxwell Taylor, the chairman of the Chiefs of Staff, proposed a compromise: “If there is no stoppage in missile work [in Cuba], chiefs recommend a strike after a reasonable period of time.” McNamara agreed, with the proviso that “I would not accept a recommendation to strike ‘now.’ ”

Before McNamara was ready to leave the meeting, the chief of the Joint Reconnaissance Group, Colonel Ralph Steakley, who had briefed Kennedy on the discovery of Soviet missile sites in Cuba on October 16, walked in. He informed those present that a U-2 airplane on a routine mission over the North Pole to collect air samples—a procedure required for monitoring possible Soviet nuclear tests—had lost its way and strayed into Soviet territory for reasons unknown. McNamara allegedly yelled: “This means war with the Soviet Union.” It was 2:03 p.m. EST. By that time the U-2 was